

WHO WAS THE MONA LISA?

Lisa Gherardini, immortalized in the *Mona Lisa*, was born in 1479. She was the oldest of seven sisters and was only 15 years old when she married Francesco del Giocondo in 1495. She was in her early 20s when Leonardo began her portrait. The name *Mona Lisa* was given to the painting by Vasari. In Italian, *mona* is a shortened form of “madonna,” and is similar to politely saying “my lady” in English. For many years, the identity of the woman in the *Mona Lisa* remained open to speculation. However, in 2005, new research confirmed that Lisa del Giocondo was indeed the subject of the world’s most famous painting.

Perhaps he did it as a favor to his father, who knew Lisa’s husband, Francesco del Giocondo, from their business dealings. Another theory is that Lisa reminded Leonardo of his mother, and he wanted to honor her memory. Leonardo never explained his reasoning, but certainly he showed a rare dedication to the painting.

